

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography in romantasy serves a dual function. It builds a believable world, sure, but it also does something more intimate: it determines if your characters can ever meet one another. A mountain range separating two kingdoms is not simply a border. It creates the only viable opportunity for an alliance through marriage. That isolated academy isn't just a cool setting. The isolation of the academy is the reason why your character can't leave this person who infuriates her.

Every river, every desert, every castle wall in your world will be either drawing your characters closer together or keeping them apart. Build geography with that in mind, and your setting ceases to be a passive backdrop and begins to create your story.

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation covers the physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance covers how physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the "romance connection" prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy functions as a **pressure system**. The physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they must rely on each other. Before you draw a map, ask yourself: *What geographic situation does my romance need?*

Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot. But the geography you foreground, the locations where scenes happen, the terrain your characters traverse, the distances

between them, should be doing something. Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

The “Pressure Cooker” Principle

The best romantasy settings act like pressure cookers: environments that create friction between your characters by compressing them together, holding them apart, or forcing impossible choices. When the physical world limits your characters’ ability to escape each other’s company or take the path of least resistance, your setting has done half the work.

Geography creates friction in three ways.

Proximity friction forces characters together despite themselves. A snowed-in mountain pass, a ship voyage with no escape, an isolated academy, a dangerous journey requiring partnership. When your characters can’t leave each other alone, they confront conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defences. Shared meals. Overheard conversations. Accidental touches in tight quarters.

That is why Basgiath War College works so well in *Fourth Wing*. The war college is carved into rugged cliffs, and even getting in requires surviving the Parapet, a lethal crossing. Once you’re inside, there’s no leaving. The sparring gym forces physical contact. The dorms provide no private space. And when Violet’s and Xaden’s dragons turn out to be mates, their biology adds yet another layer of confinement because the riders physically can’t stay apart without suffering for it. These two have to deal with each other whether they want to or not. The setting generates the romance.

Separation friction keeps characters physically apart. An ocean that takes months to cross, separate kingdoms behind a mountain range, a magical barrier that requires certain conditions for safe passage. Separation makes distance meaningful. Each time someone leaves and returns, the experience is emotionally charged, and the question of who’ll cross the divide (and what it costs them) becomes a declaration in itself.

Resource friction presents obstacles both characters must overcome. Limited water in a desert, the only pass through the mountains, a rare magical resource in contested territory, trade routes that require cooperation between enemies. As long as the people your characters represent are at odds over a piece of geography, the romantic relationship will have to address that tension.

Now consider what seals the pressure cooker tight in your world:

- **Physical trapping:** Islands, schools, sieges, ships, remote estates. Places with real boundaries that your characters cannot cross.
- **Circumstantial trapping:** Wilderness that requires your characters to partner to survive, diplomatic missions, shared exile. Situations where separating means failure or death.
- **Environmental trapping:** Storms, seasons, magic that prevents your characters from leaving. Forces outside of your characters that make leaving impossible no matter their wishes.
- **Social/political trapping:** Arranged marriages, hostage situations, obligations to the courts. Scenarios in which leaving would result in harm to their reputation, alliances or the lives of others.

Not all geography needs to cause friction. Some of it is just setting. But the geography you choose to foreground should be drawing your characters together, pulling them apart, or forcing them to choose. If your characters could simply leave each other behind, would they? If yes, your geography needs to make it impossible, too dangerous, or too costly for them to do so.

Keep these pressure cooker principles in mind as you work through this section. Every terrain, climate, border, and resource you build is a potential source of friction. At the end of this section, you'll revisit your world and identify where the pressure cookers are.

Common Geographic Patterns in Romantasy

Settings That Force Proximity

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Academy/Training Ground	Close quarters with no escape	<i>Fourth Wing, Zodiac Academy</i>
The Isolated Estate	Small cast, small space, no easy avoidance	Gothic romance, <i>Pride and Prejudice</i> variants
The Ship/Caravan	Moving container plus shared danger	Pirate romance, caravan stories
The Diplomatic Mission	Protocol and politics force constant contact in hostile territory	Enemy courts, peace talks, royal envoys
The Siege/War Camp	Cooperate or die	Military romantasy
The Sanctuary/Refuge	A shared safe haven keeps everyone together while danger waits outside	Hidden sanctuaries, rebel hideouts, temple asylum
The Prison/Captivity	Trapped together in enemy hands	Captive romance, enemies-to-lovers
The Dangerous Quest	Separating means failure	Quest stories, escort missions
The Snowed-In/Stranded	Weather traps them together	Cabin romance, "only one bed"
The Border Outpost	Duty, isolation, and danger keep a small cast in close quarters	Frontier garrisons, contested passes, remote watch posts
The Royal Court	Obligation keeps them near	Court intrigue, political marriage

Geographic Barriers That Create Stakes

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Mountain ranges	Separate nations/ cultures; make travel seasonal	Characters from opposite sides; winter trapping
Oceans	Create complete separation; make departure permanent	Letters across distance; the weight of leaving
Deserts	Isolate cultures; make resources precious	Oasis politics; survival journeys
Magical borders	Can be crossed only by certain people or under certain conditions	One character can cross, one can't
Sacred/restricted ground	Crossing violates law, religion, or taboo	Secret meetings on forbidden land; exile or scandal if discovered
War zones	Make travel deadly; create no-man's-land between peoples	Enemies from opposing sides
Political borders	Crossing means treason or exile	Forbidden love across enemy lines
Cursed/Blighted lands	Regions too dangerous to cross; require special protection	Must find another way; one character immune, one isn't
Class geography	Slums vs. palace district; social ruin to cross	Wrong-side-of-tracks romance; secret meetings in between spaces

Environmental Conditions That Affect Romance

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Harsh winters	Traps characters indoors; requires shared warmth	Forced proximity; "snowed in" scenarios
Dangerous nights	Characters must shelter together after dark	Shared watch; protective sleeping arrangements
Seasonal access	Passes close, ships can't sail, travel becomes impossible	Racing against time; trapped until spring
Resource scarcity	Sharing becomes necessary; generosity becomes meaningful	Sharing food/water; sacrifice for the other
Extreme heat	Travel only possible at night; requires shade-sharing, water rationing	Night travel intimacy; sharing precious water; heat exhaustion care
Hostile territory after dark	Monsters or predators hunt at night; must camp together for safety	One bed/bedroll situations; taking turns on watch; protective instincts
Corrupted/poisoned land	Regions that drain magic or health; must move quickly or rely on healer	Dependency on one character's abilities; racing against deterioration

These tables are starting points, not exhaustive lists. Your world's unique conditions (a magical curfew, a tide that swallows coastal roads, a mist that erases memories) can create pressure no real-world environment could. The best romantic tension comes from conditions specific to your world.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Rubber-Band World

Geography bends to suit the plot. Characters travel vast distances between chapters with no sense of time passing, and geographic features appear or disappear as needed. A mountain range exists to separate characters but conveniently vanishes when they need to reunite. If distance has no weight, separation has no stakes and reunion carries no emotional punch. Barriers that can be waved away whenever it's convenient are barriers readers stop believing in. The geography that's supposed to keep your characters apart needs to feel immovable, or the tension of being apart means nothing.

FIX

Establish your geography and travel times early, then let them constrain you. If crossing the mountains takes three weeks, that's three weeks of separation your characters have to live with, or three weeks of travelling together that changes everything. Let the physical world create problems you didn't plan for. Those problems often generate the best scenes.

Mistake #2: The Empty Map

You've got a map with named places, but none of them feel lived-in. The geography exists, but it doesn't affect anything. Geography should create culture, which creates characters, which creates conflict. If your geography doesn't explain why people are the way they are, your world is just a painted backdrop.

FIX

For every major geographic feature, ask: *How does this shape the people who live here?* Let geography explain cultural difference.

If you're unsure whether your geography is doing enough work, try this test: remove the geographic element entirely. If nothing changes about your characters' relationship or your plot, that element is set dressing, not story architecture. The geography that matters is the geography that would break something if you took it away.

Mistake #3: Geography That Doesn't Make You Feel Anything

You describe the setting in detail, but it's all physical. Mountains are tall, forests are dense, cities are crowded. None of it connects to how your characters feel. Setting should be emotional landscape. The place where they first met should feel different from other places. The character's homeland should feel like *home*.

FIX

Give each major location an emotional quality, and let characters experience it differently. The same castle might feel like a prison to one character and a sanctuary to another.

Your World Right Now

What does your world look like right now?

Before you refine anything, get your initial vision down. Continents, kingdoms, key locations, the feel of the place. Whatever you have so far, even if it's rough. This is your starting point; everything that follows will help you shape it.

YOUR ANSWER

Keep the pressure cooker principle in mind as you work through this section. Every terrain type, climate, border, and resource you develop is a potential source of friction: proximity, separation, or competition. By the end of this section, you'll revisit your world with fresh eyes and identify where the pressure cookers are.

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

How big is your world, and how long does it take to cross it?

Does your story stay within a single city, or span an entire continent? Can someone cross your world in days or does it take months? The answer shapes travel time, how isolated cultures are, and how difficult it is for characters to reach each other.

YOUR ANSWER

What is your primary kingdom or nation like?

What is it called, what is it known for, what is its main resource, and how does it shape your story? If you have a second kingdom, describe it too. This is reference material. Fill in what you know now and come back as your world develops.

YOUR ANSWER

If your world has additional kingdoms or nations, what are they like?

What is each called, what distinguishes it, and how does it relate to the romance?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the tension between your kingdoms?

Are they rivals? Allies with competing interests? Does one control something the other needs? The political geography between nations often becomes the personal geography between characters, so consider how these dynamics might shape a relationship.

YOUR ANSWER

Naming Places

Good place names make your world feel real. You don't need to invent a whole language for this; just notice how real places get their names.

Most come from geography (Blackwood, Riverside), historical figures (Washington), or descriptions in old languages (Oxford means "ford where oxen cross"). Borrow the patterns, not the exact words.

In romantasy, naming matters most when your characters come from different cultures. Distinct naming conventions instantly signal "these people are not the same." A character learning to pronounce names from their love interest's language can be a quiet intimacy beat. If your two kingdoms share naming patterns, readers assume shared heritage. If the names feel alien to each other, readers feel the cultural distance your characters have to cross.

Researching Naming Conventions

If you want place names that evoke a particular culture or aesthetic, here's how to find patterns yourself:

- **Search "[language] place name meanings"** e.g., "Old Norse place name meanings" or "Welsh place name elements"
- **Search "[language] words for [terrain]"** e.g., "Japanese words for mountain" or "Gaelic words for river"
- **Look up real places.** Search "etymology of [real place name]" to see how actual names were constructed.
- **Wikipedia's toponymy pages.** Search "[language] toponymy" for organised lists of place name elements.
- **Behind the Name.** The website behindthename.com has a place names section with etymologies.

For deeper language work, see *Section 11: Language & Communication*.

Reference: Place Name Patterns by Language

Mix prefixes and suffixes to generate names. "Ash" + "ford" = Ashford. "Black" + "moor" = Blackmoor. Pick a language that fits your world's culture, or mix elements from several.

LANGUAGE	ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
English	-ham	homestead, village	Nottingham
English	-ford	river crossing	Oxford
English	-burgh / -bury	fortified place	Edinburgh
English	-moor / -mere	marshland, lake	Windermere
English	-dale / -vale	valley	Airedale
English	-ton / -town	enclosed settlement	Kingston
Nordic	-vik / -wick	bay, inlet	Reykjavik
Nordic	-fjord / -firth	long narrow inlet	Sognefjord
Nordic	-heim / -hem	home, world	Trondheim
Nordic	-berg / -borg	mountain / fortress	Gothenburg
Nordic	-ness / -nes	headland, promontory	Skagen
Nordic	-dal / -dalen	valley, dale	Gudvangen
Celtic	Aber-	river mouth	Aberdeen
Celtic	Caer- / Car-	fort, stronghold	Cardiff
Celtic	Llan-	church, sacred enclosure	Llandudno
Celtic	Glyn- / Glen-	valley	Glencoe

LANGUAGE	ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Celtic	Loch- / Lough-	lake	Lochaber
Celtic	Dun- / Din-	hill fort	Dundee
Slavic	-grad / -gorod	city, fortified place	Belgrade
Slavic	-ov / -ova	belonging to	Sarajevo
Slavic	Novo- / Novy-	new	Novosibirsk
Slavic	Cerno- / Chern-	black	Chernobyl
Slavic	-sk / -sko	place/region suffix	Gdansk
Slavic	Belo- / Byelo-	white	Belgrade

TIPS FOR NAMING

Use multiple naming languages. If your world has multiple cultures, give each its own naming logic. Readers will intuitively feel the cultural distance between “Caerwyn” and “Novgorad” without you having to explain it.

Placeholders are fine. Don’t worry if you have no idea what to name places, people, or anything else yet. It’s completely common for authors to use placeholders like “the northern kingdom,” “the capital city,” “the mountain pass” and swap in real names later once the world has taken shape.

Your World's Place Name Patterns

Create 3-5 naming elements that fit your world's languages. What sounds right for this culture?

PREFIX / SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE LOCATION
<i>Mor-</i>	<i>sea, ocean</i>	<i>Morhaven</i>

Which locations will your story mainly take place in?

List the key places where scenes will happen: cities, courts, academies, wilderness, ships. You don't need final names yet; descriptions or placeholders work fine.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from places that sound different?

If your characters come from different cultures, distinct naming patterns instantly tell readers "these people are not the same." A character learning to pronounce names from their love interest's language can be a quiet intimacy beat.

YOUR ANSWER

Terrain Types

Only fill in terrains that matter. If your characters never see a desert, skip it.

What terrains shape your story?

TERRAIN	WHERE & WHAT IT PROVIDES	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANCE
<i>Mountains</i>	<i>Northern border; timber, isolation, seasonal passes</i>	<i>Separates the two kingdoms; crossing takes weeks</i>

What does the landscape look like between your key locations?

Rivers, forests, coastlines, plains, mountain passes. The connective geography between places matters. It determines travel routes, natural barriers, and what characters see on the journey.

YOUR ANSWER

Where do people live in your world, and why there?

People settle near water, trade routes, fertile land, or defensible positions. What drew settlers to each location? Coastal cities, river towns, mountain fortresses, desert oases. The reason people live somewhere shapes their culture.

YOUR ANSWER

What natural disasters or environmental threats exist?

Floods, earthquakes, volcanic eruptions, magical storms, blighted seasons. What does your world throw at the people living in it? These shape architecture, traditions, and the fears people carry.

YOUR ANSWER

Resources & Territorial Control

Geography tells us who has what, and who has power. Fertile land, fresh water, mineral deposits, trade routes: all valuable enough to fight wars over, to marry for, to die for. Resource control is probably the most consistent engine for romantic conflict in romantasy. It's behind the arranged marriage to secure a trade route, the tribute a king demands from a conquered kingdom, the alliance sealed by sending a princess to a court she despises. When there is an imbalance of resources, there is an imbalance of power, and that's where the tension lives.

Show resource control through what your characters can and cannot do, not exposition. A character from a land with very little water may flinch every time they see someone leaving a tub running. This awareness shows itself through small reactions, casual conversations about prices, and the constant underlying anxiety people carry about what they don't have enough of.

Reference: Natural Resource Ideas

Use this list for inspiration when filling out the table below.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Precious Metals	Gold, silver, copper, iron ore, bronze, platinum, mithril
Gems & Stones	Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, pearls, amber, jade, obsidian, marble, quality building stone
Textiles	Silk, wool, linen, cotton, rare furs, leather, spider-silk, feathers
Food & Agriculture	Grain, rice, olives, wine/grapes, sugar, honey, salt, spices, rare fruits, chocolate/cacao
Animal Products	Ivory, bone, whale oil, animal fat, beeswax, dyes from shells (Tyrian purple), ambergris
Plant Products	Timber, herbs, medicinal plants, rare flowers, resins, incense, tea, coffee, tobacco, opium
Fuel & Energy	Coal, oil, charcoal, peat, magical crystals, dragon-fire, captured lightning
Magical Resources	Ley line access, enchanted springs, magical creatures, spell components, phoenix feathers, dragon scales

What resources does your world have, and who controls them?

Think beyond the obvious. What does this world have that ours doesn't? What's scarce? What's valuable? Who has access and who doesn't?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people in your world fight over?

Water? Arable land? Trade routes? Magic? Does the conflict show up as war, political marriage, trade embargo, or something subtler?

YOUR ANSWER

How could resource imbalances shape a relationship?

Does one group control something another needs? When two people come from opposite sides of a power imbalance, their assumptions about each other become the tension.

YOUR ANSWER

Continue in Section 4

Resources & Scarcity You've mapped where resources are found and who controls them. In Section 4: *Resources & Scarcity*, you'll explore how resource control creates economic stakes, cultural traditions, and romantic tension.

Climate, Weather & Seasons

Weather affects everything: how people move through the world, their ability to grow food, warfare, daily life. Seasons can provide a deadline (marry before the snow blocks the pass), a waiting period (trapped together until the spring thaw), or simply mark the passage of time.

Weather is most effective when it creates an immediate physical problem both characters have to deal with together: wet clothes that need to come off, cold that needs to be warmed, heat that irritates. Don't tell the reader about the weather. Have the characters react to it, complain about it, make decisions based on it. The first frost. The smell of rain after months of drought. These moments show time passing better than any narration.

What's the overall climate?

Climate shapes daily life, which shapes your characters' interactions. Tropical heat, bitter cold, endless rain. Each creates different physical problems that your characters may need to solve together.

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?

Traditional four seasons? A long winter and brief summer? Magical seasons tied to something other than the sun?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

Seasons create mood and constraint. What does this season make possible for your romance? What does it prevent?

YOUR ANSWER

How do seasons affect life in your world?

When can armies march? When do ships sail? When are weddings held? When must everyone stay indoors?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the season create a deadline or a trap?

Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer? Seasons can force urgency or enforced waiting.

YOUR ANSWER

The Sensory World

Geography isn't just what exists in space. It's how it feels to be there. A first kiss in a garden filled with night-blooming jasmine feels different from one in a stone hallway with torch smoke. Filter sensory details through your POV character's emotional state. A person in love notices warmth, fragrance, softness. A grieving character sees the same garden as too bright, the flowers overpowering, the birdsong grating. Pick two or three sensory elements per scene and let the rest fade.

Avoid the "weather report" opening, where you describe your setting in neutral language before anything happens. Instead, weave the sensory details into action and emotion. Not "The room was cold," but "She tightened her cloak around her body, breath misting in the unheated chamber." When a character interacts with the world, their interaction creates both setting and feeling at once.



What would you see, hear, and feel walking through your primary setting?

Close your eyes and imagine being there. What hits your senses first? What would your protagonist notice?

YOUR ANSWER

How does this place change throughout the day?

Dawn meetings feel different than midnight ones. What time of day would be most romantic here? Most dangerous?

YOUR ANSWER

What's beautiful about this place, and what's harsh?

The details a character falling in love would notice, and the things people endure or complain about. The contrast matters: beauty and discomfort side by side make a place feel real.

YOUR ANSWER

Dangerous Regions

Every world has places that are deadly, avoided entirely or crossed only with preparation and company. Dangerous regions serve romance by raising stakes and forcing partnership. When two characters travel across hostile territory together, survival becomes the only priority, and the walls people maintain in civilised settings collapse fast.

But the danger has to land. If your characters trek through the Deadly Wastes and emerge fine, readers stop believing the world is dangerous. Let the environment cause real damage: exhaustion, injury, rationed supplies, wrong turns, fear. Write one character's competence saving the other. Write one character's vulnerability forcing the other to step up. And make the decision to enter dangerous territory feel heavy. Characters arguing about whether to go, local guides who refuse to help, maps that end at the border. Dread makes the romance that blooms inside the danger feel earned.



What regions are dangerous or forbidden?

Every world has places people warn you not to go. What makes them deadly? What would force your characters there anyway?

YOUR ANSWER

What would force people to travel through dangerous territory together?

Shared danger bonds people fast. What threats exist in your world that would require partnership to survive? The vulnerability of a dangerous journey often strips away the walls people maintain in safer settings.

YOUR ANSWER

Borders & Boundaries

Borders convert geographic areas into identities. When a mountain range or river becomes the “line” between two peoples, the people on either side define themselves relative to one another. Cross-border romance doesn’t feel merely inconvenient; it feels prohibited. The strongest borders in romantasy aren’t lines on a map. They’re lines in the minds of the characters. A character raised believing everyone on the other side of the mountains is a barbarian will carry that border inside them long after the physical one has been crossed. Make those prejudices specific and casual (assumptions about food, manners, values) and then write the moments they break down.

Consider the cost of crossing. Is it treason? Social death? Does one character risk everything while the other side doesn’t even notice? That asymmetry can drive an entire romantic arc. Borders also create “in-between” space: the neutral zone, the disputed land, the meeting point where neither character is quite at home. Many of the most honest conversations happen in these in-between zones because neither party has the comfort of home base.

What separates one place from another in your world?

Mountains, rivers, and oceans don't just separate land. They separate peoples, and the assumptions each side makes about the other. The feature you choose shapes how crossable the border feels.

YOUR ANSWER

How easy is it to cross these borders?

A border that's easy to cross creates a different kind of forbidden love than one that's physically impassable. The harder the crossing, the more it costs, and the more that cost means when someone pays it.

YOUR ANSWER

What do people on each side assume about the other?

Borders create "us" and "them." What would someone from one side casually believe about people from the other? These assumptions become personal when two people from opposite sides have to deal with each other, and the moments those assumptions crack can be powerful.

YOUR ANSWER

Home & Belonging

"Home" is one of the most emotionally charged concepts in romance. Characters may have to travel to find love, choose between love and the comfort of home, learn that home is wherever the other person is, or discover that choosing this person means exile from everything familiar. The tug-of-war between "where I belong" and "where love is taking me" creates some of romance's most powerful beats. When a character decides to remain in their lover's world, that decision is as profound as any confession.

Show it through sensory details, not statements. What does your character reach for when they're homesick? What smell takes them right back? At home, they move with ease. They know which floorboards creak, which windows stick. In unfamiliar places, they hesitate, observe, seem unsteady. The contrast does the work.

In *ACOTAR*, the Spring Court starts as a beautiful place (eternal sunshine, flowers, whimsy) but after Feyre's experience Under the Mountain, it transforms into a prison. Tamlin cages her inside the manor's wards, and the landscape that felt romantic now feels confining. When she arrives at Velaris, the hidden city of starlight parallels what Rhysand provides

emotionally: safety, creative freedom, welcome. When the Spring Court feels like a prison, that relationship is dying. When Velaris feels like home, the new love has grown roots. The geography tells the reader where Feyre's heart is long before she acknowledges it herself.



Where does your protagonist feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, and sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean "home":

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they're most themselves. How different is it from your protagonist's home?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

Fish-out-of-water moments reveal character. Where would each feel uncertain, uncomfortable, or judged?

YOUR ANSWER

Entering Each Other's Worlds

When your characters are from different areas, sending one to visit the other's territory is a big deal. Use the outsider's perspective: what confuses them, what impresses them, what unsettles them. Their reactions reveal both the world and the character. The "native" character experiences vulnerability too, suddenly aware of poverty they'd normalised, privileges they'd never considered, customs that seem bizarre when explained aloud. The tiny moments create the deepest intimacy: the love interest instinctively reaching to help with an unfamiliar task, the visitor mispronouncing a word everyone else knows, the native defending their home against criticisms they secretly agree with.

In *ACOMAF*, when Rhysand takes Feyre to Velaris, he's giving her access to his most protected secret, a city hidden from Prythian for five thousand years. The city *is* the confession. The host doesn't have to say "this is who I really am" because the geography speaks for him. This works at smaller scales too. In *Bridgerton*, a thunderstorm sends Kate into the library at Anthony's family estate, where the power dynamics of their relationship completely break down. The ancestral library becomes a sanctuary, not public enough for propriety and not private enough for scandal, and the vulnerability of that moment changes everything.



What happens when someone brings an outsider home?

Bringing someone home is an act of vulnerability. What would they be proud to show? What would they rather hide? When two people from different places visit each other's worlds, the geography itself becomes a form of honesty.

YOUR ANSWER

What do your characters notice first in an unfamiliar place?

What do they notice first? What's strange? What's beautiful? What's uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

What would a visitor understand differently after seeing this place?

What does someone from one place see differently about another's home? The poverty they'd normalised, the privileges they'd never noticed? What does the visitor finally understand after seeing where someone comes from? Place explains people.

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

When characters can go anywhere instantly, being apart has little consequence. If travelling takes weeks, every departure counts. Travel isn't filler between plot points. It's where relationships grow. It removes social boundaries and forces shared vulnerability: sleeping close enough to touch, being tired and cranky, relying on each other to survive. One person tending another's blisters. Sharing body heat in a cold camp. The required closeness of a small boat or a narrow trail.

When you write separation by distance, show the weight through what characters *can't* do: letters arriving too late, slow news, the pain of not knowing. In *From Blood and Ash*, the trip through the Blood Forest is where Poppy and Hawke develop. The continuous threat of Craven attack puts them on edge, but it's the physicality of the journey that strips away Poppy's role as the Maiden. She rides behind him. They eat by the campfire. The trail removes all formalities, and the terrain, not the conversations, allows her to transition from sheltered figurehead to someone making her own decisions.



How do people typically travel in your world?

The mode of travel shapes intimacy. Dragonback forces touching. A carriage allows conversation. Walking side by side is different from riding single-file. What does your world's travel look like, and what proximity does it create?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel Time Reference

Real-world estimates. Adjust for magic, flying creatures, or difficult terrain.

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (comfortable pace)	15-20 miles / 25-32 km	With breaks
Forced march	25-30 miles / 40-50 km	Hard to sustain
Riding (sustainable)	25-35 miles / 40-55 km	One horse, regular rest
Hard ride	40-50 miles / 65-80 km	Pushes the horse
Changing horses (relay)	80-100 miles / 130-160 km	Relay system
Sailing ship (favorable wind)	100-150 miles / 160-240 km	Weather-dependent
Carriage/wagon	20-30 miles / 32-50 km	Roads required

How far apart are your key locations?

Distance creates stakes. A week apart feels different than a year. How painful is separation in your world?

From _____ to _____ is _____ away by _____.

From _____ to _____ is _____ away by _____.

From _____ to _____ is _____ away by _____.

From _____ to _____ is _____ away by _____.

What significant journeys exist in your world?

The road is where walls come down. Long journeys strip away social roles and force shared vulnerability. What routes in your world would do that? What would the journey reveal about anyone who undertook it together?

YOUR ANSWER

Isolated Locations

Isolation is romance's secret weapon. When characters can't leave, they can't avoid each other, and avoidance is the enemy of romantic development. Establish early on why leaving isn't an option, and make that reason feel insurmountable. Then use the confined space: shared rooms, narrow hallways, common resources that require collaboration. Write the claustrophobia alongside the intimacy.

Have fun with this. On a ship, there's nowhere to go after an argument, so you're eating breakfast together whether you like it or not. At an academy, the professor keeps pairing them for sparring. In a snowed-in estate, someone has to share a bed because the guest wing is freezing. Let the setting generate its own little problems. And remember: when characters finally *could* leave but choose to stay, that choice is a declaration.



What isolated locations exist?

Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

YOUR ANSWER

Why can't people avoid each other in these places?

Isolation alone isn't enough. It's the logistics of confinement that matter. Shared meals, narrow corridors, mandatory pairings, limited beds, arguments with nowhere to storm off to. What about these spaces forces people to deal with each other?

YOUR ANSWER

Geography as Emotional Landscape

The physical world can support or oppose the emotional journey happening in your story. A first kiss in a threatening location creates urgency. The same kiss in a serene garden

conveys safety and choice. Characters see the same landscape differently depending on their emotional state. A person in love finds beauty everywhere; a broken-hearted one sees the same place as empty.

Creating “their place” is powerful: a location that becomes sacred to the relationship, whether it’s where they first met, first kissed, or survived something together. “She hadn’t been back to the bridge since that night” conveys enormous emotional weight if you’ve established that bridge means something.

In *Twilight*, Forks, Washington was chosen specifically because it’s one of the rainiest, cloudiest places in the country. The rain lets vampires live in plain sight and creates the dreamlike quality of Bella’s life. The Meadow, the one sunlit clearing where Edward can reveal himself fully, becomes symbolically tied to the romance. When Edward leaves in *New Moon*, it’s described as withered and dying. The state of the place is an indicator of the health of the love story. In *Fourth Wing*, this goes even further. Violet’s lightning and Xaden’s shadows are physical manifestations of their emotional states, and when their emotions boil over, the space around them literally can’t contain it. When the world responds to the romance, readers feel it in their bodies.



What's the emotional mood of your primary setting?

The emotional quality of a place shapes every scene that happens there. An oppressive setting adds urgency to a first kiss; a serene one implies safety and choice. Does your primary setting feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying? How does that quality interact with your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Where could the weather or landscape reflect a character's emotions?

A storm during a confrontation, sunlight breaking through as tension eases, a wilting garden reflecting something dying. Where in your world could the setting amplify or oppose the emotional beats of a scene?

YOUR ANSWER

What places could become sacred to a relationship?

A bridge where something changed, a clearing where someone was vulnerable, a room where a secret was shared. Locations become sacred to relationships when significant moments happen there. What places in your world have that potential?

YOUR ANSWER

The Pressure Cooker: Your Story

You've now explored terrain, climate, resources, borders, travel, isolation, and emotional landscape. Look back at what you've built and identify where the pressure is.

What in your world could trap people together or keep them apart?

Review what you've built in this section. Are there places people can't leave easily? Distances that take weeks to cross? Resources that multiple groups need? Consider how any of these conditions might force two people into proximity, keep them apart, or put them on opposite sides of a conflict.

YOUR ANSWER

What could make it hard to leave, and what could make it costly to stay?

The strongest settings work both ways. A besieged city is dangerous to stay in but impossible to leave. An academy offers opportunity but demands obedience. What trade-offs does your geography create, and how might those trade-offs affect a relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

Where in your world would two people have no choice but to deal with each other?

Ships, academies, sieges, mountain passes in winter, diplomatic courts. What locations or situations in your world remove the option of walking away? These are often where the most interesting romantic dynamics develop.

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

How could your geography create conflict or tension?

Contested resources, dangerous crossings, borders that divide. Where does your geography push people into disagreement or force difficult choices?

YOUR ANSWER

How could your geography shape the cultures living in it?

Mountain communities differ from coastal ones. What beliefs, traditions, or daily habits would your geography create, and where would those differences cause misunderstanding?

YOUR ANSWER

What part of your geography will readers remember most?

Which location, landscape, or geographic detail feels most alive in your world? The one readers will picture long after they finish the book?

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Key location 1	<i>The Winter Court (protagonist is hostage, love interest is prince)</i>
Key location 2	
Key location 3	
The contested resource or territory	
The barrier separating peoples or characters	
The dangerous region	
The isolated location	
The significant journey (from → to)	
The place that matters emotionally	
Other:	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Other:	

Map Making (Optional)

You don't need a map. Plenty of great fantasy stories were written without one.

That said, maps can help you keep travel times consistent and visualise where things are in relation to each other. If you decide to make one, let your story's needs guide you. How far is the border your characters are fleeing towards? Is the palace defensible? Where might lovers meet in secret? Build your geography around the situations your plot requires.

Map-Making Tools

Free options unless noted. Search these names online for current links.

- **Inkarnate** Popular fantasy map maker (free tier available)
- **Azgaar's Fantasy Map Generator** Procedural generation with editing
- **Wonderdraft** One-time purchase, professional quality
- **World Anvil** Worldbuilding wiki with map tools (subscription)

Map Making: What to Include on Your Map

Consider which of these appear in your world. You don't need all of them.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Geographic features	Mountains, rivers, forests, lakes, coastlines, islands, deserts, swamps, valleys
Political boundaries	Kingdom borders, disputed territories, neutral zones, conquered lands

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Cities & settlements	Capitals, port cities, border towns, villages, abandoned settlements
Trade & travel	Major roads, trade routes, mountain passes, river crossings, ports
Fortifications	Castles, walls, watchtowers, military camps, fortresses
Religious sites	Temples, shrines, pilgrimage routes, sacred groves, forbidden places
Magical locations	Ley lines, magical academies, cursed regions, power sources
Story-specific	Where characters meet, where they're forbidden to go, where they flee to

— ◆ —

The geography of your world is about much more than where everything is. It's why your characters can't be together easily, and what they'll have to cross, endure, or sacrifice to change that. The mountain range is why two peoples distrust each other. The desert is why whoever controls the oasis controls the trade route. The isolated academy is why two people who would never have spoken are now sharing a corridor. Build geography that explains your world and creates the pressure your romance needs.